

SCOPE PROPOSAL

Elevate 215

Elevate 215 invests in Philadelphia schools that are already beating the odds, and helps more schools get there.

Serves public, charter, and private K–8 schools across Philadelphia — 16,600+ students in its current portfolio.

Who Elevate 215 is

16,600+

Students across 35 K–8 schools in its current portfolio

93%

Of revenue from contributions and grants — William Penn Foundation, Lenfest Institute among named funders

Beat the Odds

Funds schools that significantly outperform what their demographics predict

Dr. Stacy Holland

Executive Director — final sign-off on every funding decision

How we got here

CONVERSATION 1

Traced how a funder report and the monthly board deck actually get built, step by step.

CONVERSATION 2

Went deeper on the data behind funding decisions — found the real root cause: nothing gets double-checked before it matters.

CONVERSATION 3

Tested this exact proposal with Stacy directly, and revised it based on her pushback.

Every claim in this deck traces back to something Stacy said directly — not an assumption.

Three problems, one shared cause

TIME

Funder Reporting

Three people, one week, every time a funder asks.

FINANCIAL RISK

Monthly Board Deck

A stale number reached the board before — and got caught live.

MISSION

Beat the Odds Data

Funding decisions run on one year of test scores.

THE SHARED CAUSE

"Nobody's built a way to catch mistakes before they matter."

— Stacy Holland, Executive Director

Which workflow we're solving, and why

SCOPED

Funder Reporting

Answering what a funder's money did at a school — currently three people, one week, every time.

NOT NOW

Monthly Board Deck

"Three different problems, three different kinds of risk" — equally serious, not first.

NOT NOW

Beat the Odds Data

"Don't come back and tell me something's feasible if you haven't actually looked."

SHARED CAUSE "Nobody's built a way to catch mistakes before they matter."

Before: how a funder report gets built today

Trigger — a funder emails asking what their money did at a school (8–10x/year, worse in fall)

RENÉE

Visit notes — prose, one file per school per visit

Can't search across schools — has to read every note by hand

GRANT AGREEMENT

What was promised — location varies by grant

No single home — shared drive, email, or asked verbally

PRIYA · QUICKBOOKS

Payment records — clean, one row per payment

No issue here — this source is not the problem

STACY, ALONE

Assembles all three by hand — Word doc, email, or spreadsheet

SENT

Report goes to the funder — no one else has seen it

"Nobody's checking it before it goes to the funder. It's just me."

What this actually costs today

1 week

Per funder report, start to finish

8–10x

Every year, worse in the fall

0

Review steps before a report is sent

WHY IT'S WORSE THAN IT LOOKS

In fall and winter, Renée and Marcus aren't already talking daily the way they are during spring application season — so Stacy isn't just gathering information, she's reconstructing context that used to be fresh.

After: same workflow, two things added

Trigger — unchanged. Same funder, same question, same frequency.

RENÉE · NEW

Still writes her narrative — also tags a **metric + status per visit**

Open: where the tag lives, and who reads it

GRANT AGREEMENT

Unchanged for now

Open: depends on a separate conversation about a grants system

PRIYA · QUICKBOOKS

Unchanged

Still the clean source it is today

STACY · NEW

Asks a plain question, gets an answer — no more reading every note

PRIYA · NEW

Second-look review before the report is sent

What doesn't change: Renée's visits, the agreement process, and Priya's records. Two things are added — nothing is replaced.

What Elevate 215 gets back

VISIBILITY

Renée's notes become something you can ask a question of, not something you read one visit at a time.

An answer in minutes instead of a week of reading.

ACCURACY

A second person checks the report before it reaches a funder — today, no one does.

Currently 0 of 8–10 yearly reports get a second look before sending.

DURATION

Less manual reconstruction from Renée's notes — especially under a compressed deadline.

A shorter turnaround, not just the routine week.

What's still open

Where does Renée's tag live, and who reads it?

Renée

[Date]

Does Priya have time to review, and is she the right person?

Priya

[Date]

Has a grants management system ever actually been evaluated?

Dev

[Date]

What happens next

THIS WEEK

Confirm the open questions directly with Renée, Priya, and Dev

THEN

Revise the proposal based on what they say — not what we assumed

ONCE CONFIRMED

Build the two changes and check them against the real success measures

THE ASK

We want a decision to move forward by
[Date].

Success looks like: the week becomes two days, the numbers match every time, and issues get caught before they matter.

About Elevate 215

MISSION & SCALE

Increases the number of quality schools in Philadelphia — public, charter, and private K–8.

16,600+ students in the current portfolio. Targeting 50 schools and 25,000 students by 2027.

FUNDING & LEADERSHIP

~93% of revenue is philanthropic — named funders include the William Penn Foundation and the Lenfest Institute.

Dr. Stacy Holland, Executive Director since 2021.
Investment Team: Renée Okonkwo and Marcus Feld.

Before — the workflow today

TRIGGER A funder asks what their money did at a school



SOURCE 1
Renée's notes

SOURCE 2
Grant agreement

SOURCE 3
Priya / QuickBooks



THE GAP

Assembled by hand, one week — then sent with no one else reviewing it.

After — with two changes in

TRIGGER A funder asks what their money did at a school



NEW

Renée tags each visit

SAME

Grant agreement

SAME

Priya / QuickBooks



NEW Second-look review before it's sent

Three points of friction

NO VISIBILITY

"Can't pull trends or off-track counts without asking Renée or reading every note."

NO FIXED HOME

The grant agreement's storage is inconsistent — sometimes it takes digging through email to find it.

SEASONAL GAP

Fall and winter, Renée and Marcus aren't synced daily — the bottleneck is worse most of the year.

How we'll know it worked

1 week → 2 days

And the rework disappears — no re-answering a funder's follow-up from scratch.

Every time

The number in the report matches, checked before it ever reaches a funder.

Caught early

Issues surface before they reach a funding decision, not after.

— Stacy Holland, on what success looks like

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